facilities are difficult to hide and are therefore vulnerable to air and missile attacks. India's infrastructure is relatively weak, but it has one advantage. Many of the key roads leading to the front are narrow and twisting. This slows Indian supplies, but if the Chinese broke through Indian lines they would have to slowly weave their way down these very same roads, making them highly vulnerable. Indian air, artillery, and missile fire would be able to decimate the incoming force. In addition, the further the Chinese come, the more vulnerable they will be to counterattacks. The Indian counterattacks could come against positions where the Chinese have made gains but also in other areas where India has local superiority. The result would be a chequerboard, where the Chinese gain here and the Indians gain there. Overall, China might not be in a better position.

Naval Balance

While India and China primarily worry about a land war involving ground forces and air power, the two sides could find themselves embroiled in a naval conflict. In 2019, India had a total of twenty-seven key surface combatants (aircraft carriers, destroyers, and frigates) and seventeen submarines, while China had eighty-four key surface combatants and fifty-six submarines.[22] That is, China had roughly three to four times the number of surface and submarine combatants. This somewhat underestimates the imbalance. India has two nuclear-powered submarines: one nuclear-powered attack submarine or SSN (armed with conventional weapons) and one nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine or SSBN (capable of launching a nuclear-tipped ballistic missile). China has six SSNs and four SSBNs. These are vital since they can stay below the surface for long periods of time and therefore escape detection. The SSNs can hunt down other submarines as well as surface vessels. The SSBNs on the other hand can carry nuclear weapons and so are crucial for deterrence: since they are difficult to find below the surface, they can survive a first strike by an adversary.